

# PHI 367 — Course Expectations

Summer 2026

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## Goals for the Course

Before turning to the specific expectations, it is worth saying what all of this is *for*. My goals for you this summer are not really about coverage of material. They are about who you become as a thinker. I want you to grow better at discussing ideas — advancing your own view while genuinely engaging others. I want you to become a better listener, someone who can take in what another person is really saying and learn from it, especially when you disagree. I want you to understand yourself better: your habits of mind, your blind spots, what you actually think when you slow down enough to find out. And I want you to write better, since clear writing and clear thinking are, in the end, nearly the same thing.

Those are my goals for you. But this course is also yours, and I ask you to bring your own goals to it. Early on, spend some time — in your journal is a natural place — asking what *you* want to get out of this summer. What kind of thinker do you want to become? What do you want to be able to do by the end that you cannot quite do now? Keep those goals in view as we go, and revise them as they change. *The work below will mean much more if it is in service of something you actually want.*

## What Is Expected of You

This is a working seminar in philosophy. Rather than passively absorbing material, you will practice the craft of philosophy itself: reading closely, discussing rigorously, writing regularly, and developing your own ideas toward a finished project. The expectations below describe how you will do that over the course of the summer.

## Leading Discussion

Each of you will lead class discussion twice during the course. Leading discussion does not mean delivering a lecture. It means coming prepared to open up the day's material: raising the questions worth asking, identifying the arguments worth examining, and guiding your classmates toward the difficulties that matter. Your job is to get the conversation started and to keep it moving in a productive direction.

## Keeping a Journal

You are expected to keep a running journal throughout the course. There is no required length, but I recommend roughly one page per day. The journal is a place to think on paper: to record questions, work through arguments, react to the reading, and track the development of your own ideas.

At the end of the course, you will show me your journal. You are welcome to redact anything you would prefer to keep private; I am interested in seeing that you have kept up the practice, not in reading every private thought.

## Workshopping Your Own Project

Over the course of the summer, you will develop an idea for a piece of your own philosophical work — something on the scale of an article or a short book. You do not need to have this idea fully formed at the start; part of the point is to workshop it as you go.

During the final week, you will pitch your idea to the whole class. The pitch is a chance to articulate what your project is, why it matters, and how you would carry it out.

Each pitch will follow the same format:

- **The pitch (about 12 minutes).** You present your idea: what the project is, why it matters, and how you would go about it.
- **A response (about 3 minutes).** Another student, assigned in advance, offers prepared comments — questions, objections, or suggestions.
- **Open discussion (a few minutes).** We open the floor and everyone joins in.

To show you what this looks like, the professor and the teaching assistant (João) will run through the exercise themselves sometime this coming week — one of us pitching, the other responding. Treat it as a model, not a template: there is more than one way to give a good pitch.

You are not required to actually write the paper. But if you choose to, the professor and the teaching assistant will read it and give you feedback.

## The Professor's Project

I will not be asking you to do anything I am not doing myself. Over the course of the summer, I will be writing an article, and I will regularly bring you into the discussion of my own process — the false starts, the revisions, the choices about how to frame an argument. The aim is to make the work of doing philosophy visible, so that your own projects have a model to react to and learn from.

## A Word on AI

We are all, together, learning how to integrate AI into serious intellectual work, and I want us to take that challenge on openly rather than pretend it isn't there. The goal is to use these tools to become better thinkers and writers than we could have been without them — to push our ideas further, to test our arguments against a tireless interlocutor, to catch what we would otherwise have missed.

But there is a real and opposite danger: that we let AI replace the very process it should be sharpening. The struggle of working through an argument, of not yet knowing what you think, of writing your way toward clarity — that struggle is not an obstacle to the work. It *is* the work, and it is where the growth happens. A tool that spares you the struggle may also spare you the learning.

So I ask you to be deliberate and honest about how you use AI in this course — with me, with each other, and with yourself. Part of what we are doing this summer is figuring out, in practice, where these tools genuinely make us better and where they quietly stand in for the thinking we ought to be doing ourselves. Your journal is a good place to reflect on that question as it comes up.

One experiment worth trying: ask an AI for feedback on the more personal, reflective entries in your journal — the ones where you are working out what you actually think. It can be a surprisingly useful mirror, and noticing when its feedback helps and when it flattens or misreads what you meant is itself part of learning to use these tools well.

## Summary of Expectations

- Lead class discussion twice during the course.
- Keep a running journal (about a page a day recommended), to be shown to me — possibly redacted — at the end of the course.
- Develop and pitch an idea for your own philosophical project during the final week: about 12 minutes to pitch, 3 minutes for an assigned respondent, then open discussion.

Writing the paper is optional, but feedback is available if you do.

- Take part in ongoing discussion of the professor's own writing project.